Purim Katon 5784

This year, as an עיבור יאר, we have two Purims - פורים קטן and פורים גדול. And we're lucky in that respect. Here's a small הערה which I had the זכות to hear from R' Aryeh Strickhoff, the author of the well-known book Inside Purim, regarding פורים קטן, and I thought it would be worthwhile to share it with you. פורים, as we know, is a זמן that is מסוגל for תפילה. Just as אסתר's תפילה was מקובל, so too, throughout all the דורות, תפילות on פורים and תענית אסתר have been especially potent. תענית אסתר is particularly מסוגל for תפילה, even though it's not actually the day she fasted - the fast originally took place on פסח - but it is still a special time for תפילות. So what does that wily יצר הרע do? He keeps us running around on פורים with משלוח מנות. We're busy giving פעקלעך, getting פעקלעך, kids getting tips - where is the תפילה? His מקור is the famous משנה in בין אין מגילה, אין בין. The first אין בין that we have is אין בין אדר ראשון לאדר שני, that the פורים in אדר ראשון does not have קריאת מגילה and does not have מתנות לאביונים. It happens to leave out משלוח מנות, and the מפרשים talk about that, but his הערה was that משלוח מנות, in a very real sense, takes away from some of the עיקר of the יום טוב. The עיקר is עבודת השם, as is everything that we do. Of course, when we do משלוח מנות, we are מקיים the מצוה, and we should not feel bad about it. However, my own personal suggestion (not his) is to keep a תהילים in the car. As the kids run from house to house, say a פרק תהילים between each stop - not only for ארץ ישראל, but for us too. Now back to his point: why did Hashem, for our זכות, give us a פורים קטן this year and in all עיבור שנים? Because on פורים קטן, we are not busy running around with משלוח מנות. However, the סגולה of תפילות being מקובל remains just as strong. That means we have an extra opportunity, an extra chance, and an extra זכות to have our תפילות answered. So let's do that on this פורים קטן. Let's daven our hearts out. Let's daven for כלל ישראל, let's daven for ארץ ישראל, let's daven for us, let's daven for all ישראל, all around the world. Because this פורים קטן there's no משלוח מנות, that's for sure. But we can daven, and we can daven very well. So that's from R' Aryeh Strickhoff, I want to give credit where credit is due, הָאוֹמֵר דָּבָר בְּשֵׁם אוֹמְרוֹ מֵבִיא גְּאֻלָּה לָעוֹלָם (אבות ו:ו). So I wanted to share that with you.

It is brought down in the ספר כנפי השכינה that the letters of the word פורים contain all of the ימים טובים, showing that they are all connected to פורים. It's interesting how he says it. פורים: פ is פסח, ו is וסוכות, [a little bit שוור there], ר is ראש השנה, י is יום כיפור, and מ is מתן תורה for שבועות. So what's fascinating here is that the ו, which stands for וסוכות, could also mean "and". What does that "and" represent? It means that both Purims, פורים קטן and פורים גדול, are to be considered ימים טובים.

Another vort that I would like to share that with you is from the sefer אִגֶּרֶת פורים. The Apter Rav, R' Avraham Yehoshua Heshel, made a סעודה for all of his תלמידים and his חסידים on פורים קטן. Among the people sitting at his פורים קטן סעודה was a Chassidish Rebbe named R' Lieb M'Lichev. He was a well-seasoned תלמיד חכם. During the סעודה, the Apter Rav turned to R' Leib and said, "Leib, let's hear something from you! Enlighten us with your words." R' Leib smiled and responded, "The מנהג of the world is that when a woman is pregnant, she gives birth to a קטן - a ילד קטן, a תינוק. A בהמה מעוברת gives birth to a בהמה קטנה. But if you have a שנה מעוברת, what kind of קטן does a שנה מעוברת bring forth?" Nobody had an answer. He laughed and said, "It's פשוט! A שנה מעוברת brings out a פורים קטן!" So I thought that was adorable, and it really puts us into the proper frame of mind to get ready for the פורים גדול. We should be בשמחה.

After מרדכי heard about המן's גזירה, he put on שק ואפר as a sign of אבלות over the terrible decree. The פסוק tells us that אסתר sent him clothing so that he would remove his sackcloth, but he refused - he did not want to accept the clothing she sent. The תפארת שלמה asks: did מרדכי not have any clothing? Of course, he did! He had put on the שק ואפר as a statement about the dire situation. So why did אסתר send him clothing? Was he lacking shirts?

אסתר was suggesting there was a better way to daven, a means of תפילה that would be much more effective. While the situation called for שק ואפר, she was saying, "Your תפילות need to be offered in the spirit of שמחה!" In sending the clothing, אסתר was telling מרדכי that he had to daven with confidence and joy, that's the way to tear up the evil decree. What did מרדכי say? מרדכי's response was, "No! I am

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צעבראכן, and my תפילות have to reflect that." Who was right? Later in the מגילה, אחשורוש commands המן to dress מרדכי in the royal clothing and parade him through the street on the king's horse. Right after that, מרדכי's תפילות were accepted. In שמים, they paskened like אסתר. When מרדכי's תפילות came from a place of שמחה, triumph, and excitement, he was answered. The גמרא מגילה relates that when אחשורוש dispatched המן to go and bring מרדכי and lead him through the streets on the horse, he found מרדכי davening. The גמרא clearly says המן waited for him to finish. This is astounding! The בן יהוידע asks, "Why would a רשע wait for a צדיק to daven?" R' Elimelech Biderman, who was saying over this דבר תורה, emphasizes each word to make his point as persuasively as possible: It's because he saw that מרדכי was צעבראכן, filled with anguish and pain. He didn't want to interrupt that with good news, because that would elevate the whole תפילה, and would enable מרדכי to finish davening in a state of שמחה. המן knew that! A תפילה filled with שמחה is different than a תפילה of צער. Have a very happy פורים קטן!

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